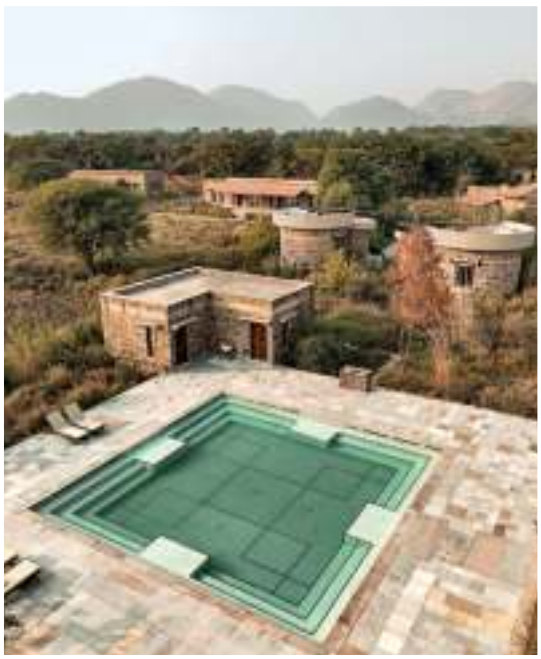
EMBEDDED IN NATURE
Top left and right, the Sariska Lodge melds with its environs; below, a statue of Jain Tirthankara Shantinath at the temple complex near Sariska





Like me, the countryside is on holiday. Walking along the road are pilgrims on their way to the mela at the Baba Bhartrihari temple in the forest. We pass groups of women, red and yellow *odhnis* over their heads and sturdy backpacks behind. The driver explains that, during this lull in the labour of farming, villagers take time off to visit the temple of the king-turned-ascetic. The trek is tough, but charitable villagers along the way organise community kitchens to feed the pilgrims. Indeed, we soon come across a roadside clearing where turbanned men are stirring a giant pan of *aloo sabzi* and frying *poori*s in a huge *karhai*. Everyone, including passers-by like us, are lovingly urged to eat. So, we go on, snacking our way through *kachori*, *jalebi* and *moong vade*, surprised and pleased at this unexpected treat.



We are still burping away happily, when the car deposits us at Sariska Lodge, right by the Sariska Tiger Reserve entrance at Tehla. The sound